

Coral Recovery Monitoring, Wrightsville Sound

Interim Progress Report, Fall 2025 to Winter 2026

Prepared by	Darren Mitchell Cash, undergraduate research assistant
Advisor	Professor Karen Whitfield
Reporting period	October 2025 to February 2026
Report date	February 26, 2026

Summary

This period covered ten survey dives across four monitoring sites in Wrightsville Sound. The goal was to track hard and soft coral colony counts and bleaching incidence through the cooler months following the 2024 bleaching event. Across the four sites the share of healthy colonies climbed steadily as water temperatures dropped, with the clearest gains at Masonboro Ledge and Five Mile Ledge. Bleached colony counts fell at every site between the October and February surveys.

Site	First survey healthy %	Latest survey healthy %	Change
Masonboro Ledge	85.0	90.0	+5.0
Crystal Pier Reef	84.4	90.7	+6.3
Five Mile Ledge	90.6	89.1	-1.5
Liberty Rocks	71.4	82.1	+10.7

Methods

Each site was surveyed along two fixed transects of twenty five meters. Colonies within one meter of the line were counted and classed as hard coral, soft coral, or bleached. Depth, visibility, and water temperature were logged at the start of each dive. Photo quadrats were taken at five meter intervals for later review. All counts were entered to the shared research base on the evening of each survey.

Next steps

Surveys continue on the biweekly schedule. The next reporting block will fold in the warm season counts and begin the recovery rate analysis for the thesis proposal. Two photo quadrat sets from Crystal Pier Reef need a reshoot after silt reduced visibility in late October. A short methods note on transect spacing has been drafted for the lab protocol page.